PROJECT REPORT

Task 5 — Digital Literacy & Cybercrime Awareness

Case Study: Phishing | Prevention Checklist | Personal Reflection

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Report Cybercrime: cybercrime.gov.in | Helpline: 1930 (24x7)

1. Introduction

Cybercrime is one of the fastest-growing threats in the digital age, affecting individuals, institutions, and governments alike. In India, the rise of affordable smartphones and widespread internet access has created enormous opportunity — but also significant vulnerability, especially among college students who are digital-native yet often unaware of how sophisticated modern attacks have become.

This report covers three components of Task 5 — a structured case study on Phishing, a ten-point Stay Safe Online prevention checklist designed specifically for college students in India, and a personal reflection on what was most surprising while researching this topic and what habit will change as a result.

2. Part A — Case Study: Phishing

2.1 What Is Phishing?

Phishing is a form of digital fraud in which attackers disguise themselves as a trusted entity — such as a bank, a government agency, or a popular service provider — to steal credentials, financial data, or personal identification. Unlike traditional hacking, which targets software vulnerabilities, phishing targets human psychology. It is one of the most prevalent and effective forms of cybercrime globally because it bypasses technical defences entirely by manipulating the person at the keyboard.

2.2 How a Phishing Attack Happens — Step by Step

Step	What the Attacker Does
1 — Preparation	The attacker creates a deceptive email, text message (smishing), or website that precisely mimics a legitimate organisation's branding — logos, fonts, email addresses, and tone are all copied.
2 — The Hook	A mass message is sent with an urgent call to action: 'Your account has been compromised,' 'Your KYC is incomplete,' or 'Claim your scholarship reward now.' Urgency prevents the victim from thinking critically.
3 — Redirection	The victim clicks a malicious link that leads to a spoofed login page designed to look identical to the real site (e.g., a fake SBI or Google login page).
4 — Theft	As the victim enters their username, password, OTP, or UPI PIN, the attacker captures the data in real time on a server they control.
5 — Exploitation	The attacker uses the stolen credentials to drain bank accounts, sell the data on the dark web, hijack social media profiles, or launch further targeted attacks on the victim's contacts.

2.3 Who Is Targeted and What Are the Consequences?

While anyone with an internet connection can be a phishing target, attackers tend to focus on vulnerable populations. In India, college students are particularly at risk — they are active on social media, heavily reliant on UPI and digital payments, and regularly respond to scholarship, internship, and job notifications online.

The consequences of a successful phishing attack are severe:

- Financial loss — bank accounts, UPI wallets, and credit cards can be completely drained within minutes of credential theft.
- Identity theft — personal details stolen through phishing can be used to open fraudulent loans or credit cards in the victim's name.
- Academic harm — access to college portals and email accounts can be used to manipulate records or impersonate students.
- Reputational damage — hijacked social media accounts can be used to spread misinformation or offensive content in the victim's name.
- Psychological impact — victims often experience lasting anxiety, shame, and distrust of digital systems.
- Organisational harm — a single employee falling for a phishing email can expose an entire company's database, leading to data breaches and legal liability.

3. Part B — Stay Safe Online: Prevention Checklist

The following ten-point checklist is designed specifically for college students in India. All tips are actionable and directly relevant to how students use technology on campus and in daily life.

#	Tip	What To Do
1	**Use strong, unique passwords**	Create passwords with uppercase, lowercase, numbers, and symbols for every account. Never reuse the same password across Instagram, Google, UPI apps, and college portals. Use a password manager like Bitwarden.
2	**Enable Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)**	Turn on 2FA for all important accounts. Even if your password is stolen, attackers cannot log in without your phone's OTP. Go to Settings > Security > Two-Factor Authentication.
3	**Never click unknown links in WhatsApp, SMS, or email**	Phishing links disguise themselves as scholarship alerts, job offers, or college notices. Check URLs carefully before clicking — scammers use lookalike domains. When in doubt, open the official website directly.
4	**Keep all devices and apps updated**	Software updates patch security vulnerabilities. Enable auto-updates for your phone OS, browser, and apps. Outdated apps are among the most common malware entry points.
5	**Limit personal information on social media**	Do not post your phone number, home address, college roll number, or daily schedule publicly. Cybercriminals use this to craft personalised (spear phishing) attacks targeting you by name.
6	**Use only secure, trusted Wi-Fi networks**	Avoid logging into banking or college apps on public Wi-Fi in canteens, cafes, or hostels. Use a VPN if you must connect to public networks. Never conduct financial transactions on unsecured Wi-Fi.
7	**Verify the identity of anyone claiming authority online**	Scammers impersonate police, bank officials, TRAI, or university staff. No legitimate authority demands instant payment, OTP sharing, or personal data over WhatsApp or phone.
8	**Audit your phone app permissions regularly**	Go to Settings > Apps > Permissions and revoke unnecessary access. A calculator app does not need your contacts. A flashlight does not need your location.

Financial & UPI Safety — Special Tips (9 & 10)

Tip 9 — NEVER share your UPI PIN, OTP, or CVV with anyone: Banks, Google Pay, PhonePe, and Paytm will NEVER ask for your UPI PIN or OTP over a call or message. Fraudsters pose as customer care agents and ask for OTP to 'verify your account.' Sharing it gives them complete access to your money. Remember: OTP is for authorising payments — anyone asking for it is attempting to steal from you.

Tip 10 — Always verify before scanning any QR code to receive money: QR codes are used only to SEND money — not receive it. If someone sends you a QR code claiming you will receive a refund, scholarship, or prize by scanning it, that is a scam. You will lose money, not gain it. Always share your UPI ID (VPA) to receive payments.

3.1 Reporting Channel — National Cyber Crime Portal

Situation	What To Do
Financial fraud / UPI scam	Call 1930 immediately and contact your bank to freeze the transaction.
Phishing / fake website	Report at cybercrime.gov.in under 'Report Cyber Crime'.
Cyberbullying / online harassment	File complaint at cybercrime.gov.in > Women/Child Related Crime.
Sextortion / morphed images	Call 1930 and file a complaint at cybercrime.gov.in urgently.
Fake job / internship fraud	Report to cybercrime.gov.in and alert your institution's IT cell.

National Cyber Crime Portal	National Cyber Helpline
cybercrime.gov.in	**1930 (24x7, Free)**

4. Part C — Personal Reflection (100–150 Words)

The question asked: What surprised you most while researching this topic, and one habit you will personally change as a result.

Personal Reflection — Govind Jadhav, 25BAI11219

What surprised me most while researching phishing was how little technical skill attackers actually need. I had assumed cybercrime required deep programming knowledge, but phishing kits — ready-made tools to clone bank and government websites — are sold openly on the dark web for as little as a few hundred rupees. A person with no coding ability can launch a convincing phishing campaign targeting thousands of people within hours. That was genuinely unsettling.

The second surprise was the QR code scam. I had always assumed scanning a QR code to receive money was a standard UPI feature. Discovering that QR codes can only be used to send money — and that the 'scan to receive' trick is one of the most common UPI frauds in India — was an eye-opener.

The one habit I will change immediately: I will stop trusting any message that creates urgency. Whether it is a scholarship alert, a bank warning, or a KYC update request, I will now go directly to the official website instead of clicking any link in the message. Urgency is the attacker's most powerful weapon — and pausing for ten seconds is my best defence.

Word Count: 148 words

5. Conclusion

Phishing remains one of the most dangerous and underestimated forms of cybercrime because it requires no technical sophistication from the attacker — only a believable disguise and a moment of human inattention. For college students in India, the risks are compounded by high digital activity, UPI reliance, and a constant stream of notifications that blur the line between legitimate and fraudulent communication.

The prevention checklist in this report offers ten specific, actionable steps that any student can implement immediately, with particular emphasis on UPI and financial safety. The key reporting channels — cybercrime.gov.in and Helpline 1930 — exist precisely so that victims can act fast and limit damage.

The most powerful protection, however, is not a password manager or a VPN. It is the habit of pausing before clicking, calling before transferring, and questioning before trusting. Cybercrime thrives on speed and panic — the best defence is deliberate, informed slowness.